



“Men were going to die in the air as they had for centuries on the ground and on the seas, by killing each other. The conquest of the air was truly accomplished.”

RENÉ CHAMBE

AU TEMPS DES CARABINES

WORKING FOR THE GENERALS

THE PRINCIPLE ROLE OF AIRCRAFT IN WORLD WAR I WAS TO SUPPORT THE ARMIES IN THE TRENCHES – AIRMEN GAVE THEIR LIVES FOR MEN ON THE GROUND

AT THE OUTBREAK OF WAR in Europe in August 1914, aircraft did not seem set to play a serious part in the conflict. The ground forces of the major European armies were counted in millions; the frontline aircraft deployed by all combatants amounted to little over 500 fragile, unarmed monoplanes and biplanes. Caught up in the patriotic fervor of the moment, civilian pilots rushing to join up included such well-known stars of peacetime aviation as Roland Garros and Jules Védrines. But the military establishments initially had little use for the skills of the daredevil sportsman-aviators who had so recently enthralled the public.



FIRST BLOOD

Roland Garros, the prewar aviation pioneer who made the first Mediterranean crossing, was the first World War I pilot to shoot down an enemy plane by firing through his propeller blades (see page 73).

in unfamiliar territory while trying to avoid becoming hopelessly lost and coping with unpredictable weather. Low cloud hampered observation and the sheer flimsiness of the machines led to frequent accidents and forced landings.

The appearance of aircraft was greeted with volleys of rifle fire from friend and foe alike. And after undergoing these hazards, airmen sometimes saw their reports simply disregarded by the crustier generals who distrusted information from such a novel source.

A vital role

Nonetheless, aerial reconnaissance made a decisive contribution to both fronts. In the east, the Russians failed to make effective use of the few aircraft they possessed, while the Germans employed their Taubes to crucial advantage. Ranging over the forests and lakes of East Prussia, German aviators located the advancing Russian armies, giving the high command time to move reinforcements to the front. When battle was joined at Tannenberg, information from aerial observers let the numerically inferior Germans concentrate their forces in the right place at the right time to carry off an epic victory.

In the west, French and British aviators were caught up in a rapid retreat across France as the gray columns of the German army swept toward Paris. Anticipating triumph, on August 29, 1914, a German pilot flew round the Eiffel Tower and dropped a single bomb on the city. But on September 3, French aircraft assigned to the defense of their capital, reported that the enemy's armies had

Aerial chauffeurs

Army pilots were essentially aerial chauffeurs. Their job was to ferry an observer – sometimes a senior officer – over the countryside to report on the movement of enemy troops. In the first months of the war there was plenty of movement to observe, with rapid advances, encirclements, and desperate retreats. In the west, the German forces overran Belgium and advanced on Paris, while in the east the Russians marched menacingly

into East Prussia. Flying mostly from improvised airstrips (any unplowed field) close to the ever-shifting front line, pilots and observers roamed the thinly populated skies, seeking out bodies of enemy troops and recording their size, location, and direction of march in scribbled notes and hastily sketched maps. It was no easy task to locate the enemy



ELEGANT GERMAN FIGHTER

Over 3,000 Albatros D.Vs (replica shown) were built in 1917–18, providing a mount for many German aces. But despite its streamlined monocoque fuselage and elegant lines, the D.V was outclassed by Allied fighters. In July 1917, a German pilot wrote: “The D.V is so antiquated and laughably inferior that we can do nothing with it.”